My hunting was restricted to birds and animals, including partridge, duck, wild boar and deer, which we would take home for the table, or if we were on an overnight trip, cook over the campfire.

I’ve only had a couple of big game encounters, once when I shot a leopard. I must admit that this was one of the most frightening experiences of my life. We were at the Kothi resthouse, along the timber trail in Himachal Pradesh, when I spied a spotted animal sitting on a rock. Thinking that it was a spotted deer or chital, I picked up my gun and shot at the animal, which leapt up and disappeared. We tried to search for it, but could find no blood trails, but then, when I peered into a cave below, I saw a pair of bloodshot eyes staring back at me. It was only then that I realized to my horror that the spotted animal was actually a leopard! Fortunately, my reflexes were quick, and I shot it dead.

My next encounter was when I was walking through the jungle and saw, through the trees, a tigress with two cubs. Not wanting to disturb their frolic, I quickly took a step back and slunk away. I had many such interesting encounters.